# More Man Utd flaws to the fore but Carrick relief comes as Martinez calls out Wilcox

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# More Man Utd flaws to the fore but Carrick relief comes as Martinez calls out Wilcox

It sums up Manchester United's predicament that a Champions League defeat which displayed deficiencies at both ends can be held up as an improvement.

Here, though, is where Michael Carrick finds himself. He will return from Atletico Madrid on the back of a 2-0 loss no safer in his job – but in no more peril. And misery may now have some company.

In Madrid, at least Carrick could point to solutions found to fix **a midfield that was ravaged by winless Tottenham Hotspur** on Saturday.

But, on this occasion, Carrick was let down by sloppiness at the back and, more than anything, an abject lack of potency up front.

It took less than a minute for Atletico to rip through a defence starting together for the first time as a back four.

Actually, the hosts tore through the entire United team in the build up to their opener which crept over Senne Lammens' line with 53 seconds on the clock.

Having copped so much criticism for the lack of intent in their press against Spurs, the United players at least feigned some eagerness, waiting on the front foot as Cristian Romero stood on the ball by his own box.

Two passes through the middle of the pack, though, took out 10 blue shirts. Perhaps the ease of it confused Diogo Dalot – it doesn't tend to take much – since he was caught looking the wrong way as Alex Baena scampered in behind him. Baena's pass across found Pablo Barrios, whose effort was half-blocked by Ayden Heaven but, typical of Carrick's luck, the ball eked over the line.

United were unfortunate earlier in the move. Romero's pass was semi-intercepted by Carlos Baleba but Atletico pounced on the loose ball. A single inadvertent touch, though, was all it took for Carrick's press to cave in. Atletico's incisiveness made sure they could never recover from there.

At least they regained some composure and United deserve some credit for that. Given their run and the flak being flung at them, they were half-expected to fold. Instead, the Red Devils should have flipped the scoreline inside a quarter of an hour.

Bryan Mbeumo wasted one glorious chance shortly before Marcus Rashford air-kicked another. There was even less conviction in Mbeumo's second attempt – also saved by Jan Oblak – before Baleba's weak header from the corner that followed was easily fielded by the Atletico keeper.

That lack of ruthlessness was the theme of the night for United. At least before Lisandro Martinez unloaded in the immediate aftermath.

Martinez, of course, was right to call out, well, almost everyone. His words were pointed more towards the boardroom and the layer between the manager and owners, which is where Jason Wilcox currently cowers.

He, not Carrick, should take the blame for United being so blunt in attack. Of course they needed to rebuild their midfield in the summer, but how can an organisation with United's resources only do one job at once?

United seem weirdly proud of conducting their recruitment while wearing blinkers, as if there is something pioneering about it. Of course, there isn't because just down the road, Liverpool seemed to take a similar approach, which has f***ed them too.

Carrick needed midfielders, a striker and defenders – in that order. Failing to buy a forward not only to cover Benjamin Sesko but to push him too, was a dereliction of duty. Of course, it wouldn't be Wilcox to pay the price, or even face the scrutiny.

Sure, those to whom the chances fell should have finished them off, but United only ever seem to go through on goal in hope rather than expectation. Bruno Fernandes is usually the most ruthless but even he was off target in the second half. Which might be attributed to the injury he is clearly carrying.

United's chances dried up when Leny Yoro was sent off for a brush with Jonathan David as last man with quarter of an hour to go. Carrick described it as a 'poor decision' and, typical of the bloke, he was being polite. Because it was a dreadful call.

Again, typical of the manager's luck, Atletico's second came as Harry Maguire and Matheus Cunha waited to come on to prompt a change in United's shape. If they didn't look confident of scoring one, two was always beyond them.

The biggest favour performed for Carrick by his players came after defeat from Martinez at the mic. The spotlight on the manager won't fade – Martinez pinpointed a lack of evolution in United's play – but maybe now the focus will widen where it needs to.

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